

CoARA Action Plan - Mälardalen University

This is the first version of Mälardalen University's action plan for the work on the commitments within the framework of the Coalition in Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) and the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA).

So far, the university's work has primarily been in a mapping phase, which is reflected in this action plan. The action plan will be updated annually and continuously developed throughout the implementation of the commitments.

Mälardalen University's aim is for the commitments to invoke a common and broadened approach to research quality and academic competence, both within the university as well as nationally and internationally. The subsequent work is expected to involve a review and possible further development of, for example, the university's research evaluation and how we view merit value and career paths.

Mälardalen University

Mälardalen University joined CoARA in January 2024. The principles and commitments in the agreement are well aligned with our vision and ongoing initiatives and development work.

Mälardalen University (www.mdu.se) is Sweden's newest university. With our vision – to be a progressive and collaborative university where together we shape a sustainable future – we aim to make a real difference. Around 18,000 students are enrolled in our courses and programs, and we offer education and conduct research in business, healthcare, engineering and technology and educational sciences.

One of our goals is to be a co-creating university. Together, we contribute to a more sustainable future through knowledge, innovation and collaboration. We believe that new knowledge, new perspectives and excellence are best created and achieved in collaboration with others - colleagues, students, private industry and the public sector, both nationally and internationally. Collaboration is an integral part of our education and research. Our education and research is conducted in collaboration with other parts of society to increase its quality and impact. Another important principle is the close integration of education and research.

Several aspects of the university's quality assurance system are in line with the CoARA commitments. Our recurring evaluations of both education and research are already carried out primarily through qualitative methods such as self-assessment and peer review. Historically, MDU has not engaged extensively with ranking lists and intends, in line with ARRA, to further develop this approach. Already ongoing work at the University aims to accelerate the transition towards open science.

We have also begun efforts to implement the guidelines in the "European Charter for Researchers" and "Guidelines for the Recruitment of Researchers". This is expected to contribute to the development of structured recruitment processes at the university.

Activities in 2024 and early 2025

The initial work following Mälardalen University's joining of CoARA in early 2024 has focused on increasing awareness within the organisation and initiating reflections on what the commitments may entail for the university. Initial efforts have included discussions within the University's own Research Council and its Faculty Board. Mälardalen University has joined the Swedish national chapter of CoARA and is actively participating in three working groups focusing on responsible bibliometrics, incentives for open science and merit recognition in collaboration and societal impact.

Mälardalen University is also participating in the SWE-CAM project, which aims to lay the foundation for developing a Swedish merit assessment tool. Within this project, the University has conducted a pilot study testing a merit diagram for visualizing collaboration-related merits. The pilot study also contributes to increased knowledge and understanding within the university regarding the merit value of collaboration.

In 2024, a follow-up of a research evaluation conducted in 2021 was carried out. As part of this follow-up, questions were asked about how well the research evaluation aligned with the CoARA commitments. The responses indicated that the evaluation could be further developed to better reflect diversity in scientific contributions and indicated a need for flexibility in addressing subject-specific needs and adaptations.

Planned activities 2025-2028

The activities below are based on current knowledge and conditions. Several factors may affect the timing and implementation of some activities, especially an ongoing reorganization of the university, but also ongoing efforts to implement the European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for

the Recruitment of Researchers through HRS4R. External development efforts, such as those within the Swedish national CoARA chapter, may also influence coming activities.

As a part of sharing progress and experiences within the coalition, MDU plans to follow up and update the action plan annually. Additional activities or more detailed descriptions of the listed activities will be added with each annual update.

1. Participate in development work and exchange experiences outside the university.
 - Mälardalen University is affiliated with the Swedish national CoARA chapter and participates in three working groups focusing on Responsible bibliometrics, Incentives for open science, and Merits in relation to collaboration with the surrounding society and utilization of research.
 - The Deputy Vice-Chancellor for Collaboration participates in the SWE-CAM project, which aims to create a basis for developing a Swedish merit assessment tool
2. Spread and increase awareness of and engagement in ongoing and planned development within MDU. A key aspect is involving teaching and research staff in the review and development process.

The University has identified three focus areas:

3. **Merits recognition and career paths:**

- a) Initial investigations: What types of merits do we want to value, and how? How can different disciplinary traditions be considered? What are we doing today, and what needs to be developed and made more visible?
- b) Develop and further refine processes, policy documents, principles, criteria, and tools for assessing researchers' merits based on the results.
- c) Provide guidance and support in using the developed processes and tools.
- d) Implement changes, including providing guidance and support, , and conduct follow-ups and further development.

4. **Research evaluation:**

- a) Test adaptations for a broader view of scientific contributions through upcoming evaluations of strategic research initiatives.
- b) Investigate: How can the University's research evaluation process incorporate a broader perspective on research quality? How can various disciplinary traditions be taken into account?
- c) Further develop the University's research evaluation approach based on CoARA's principles in preparation for an upcoming evaluation in 2028.

5. Allocation model for research funding:

- Investigate whether the University's allocation model for research funding needs to be adjusted based on CoARA's principles

Follow-up

The action plan and the development work will be followed up annually and updated in response to ongoing developments.

Contacts

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